highlight how IOs' responses to populist challenges can bolster their resilience but may also amplify the very threats they seek to neutralize.

IOs' defensive strategies often come with trade-offs that can affect their legitimacy and exacerbate the very populism they seek to counter. Populists already perceive IOs as elitist and overreaching, imposing constraints on national sovereignty. IO actions can reinforce these narratives in several ways.

First, engaging with populists behind closed doors to maintain cooperation risks making IOs appear even more opaque and unaccountable, alienating both populists and nonpopulists alike if these covert communications are uncovered.

Second, efforts to engage populists' constituents, such as using populist-friendly rhetoric or emphasizing grassroots benefits, may address transparency concerns but could alienate the IOs' traditional supporters, who may view such tactics as pandering or simplistic. Populist supporters, too, may find this rhetoric inauthentic—IOs are often perceived as untrustworthy when promoting their own brands (Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023).

Third, sidelining populist leaders can validate their criticisms of IOs as elite-dominated bodies that marginalize dissenting voices. By reducing populists' ability to influence policy and access the benefits of membership, sidelining lowers the costs of noncooperation, encouraging further retrenchment.

Fourth, appeasing populist leaders with concessions or reforms may embolden them, providing public victories they can exploit domestically while fueling perceptions among nonpopulist members that the IO is unfairly biased or politically compromised.

Indeed, populism not only fractures IOs internally but also reshapes power dynamics within them. Concessions made to appease populist states —whether through reduced requirements or increased influence—often empower these actors disproportionately. Populists, in turn, can leverage this newfound power to undermine the IO's traditional objectives. For example, populist leaders may weaken enforcement mechanisms, challenge accountability measures, or reduce constraints on member states. Trump's campaign to cripple the WTO's dispute settlement system and African states' resistance to international courts exemplify this trend (see Voeten 2020). By weakening IO autonomy, populists make it easier for states to flout